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Does Pico argue that God is beyond being or being itself? Is he closer to Thomas Aquinas on god as ipsum esse subsistens, or Averroes? Of Being and Unity

(De Ente et Uno)

By Giovanni Pico della Mirandola

translated by Victor Michael Hamm, 1943.1
NOTES:

1. In this translation I have used the text of the 1557 (Venice) edition of Pico's Opera Omnia, as reprinted by Festugière in Archives d'Histoire Doctrinale et Littéraire du Moyen Age Vol. VII (1932), pp. 208-224, which text I have compared with that of the 1519 edition, available to me at the Newberry Library, Chicago. I have been aided by Father Festugière's French version of the Latin

original, as well as by his notes. I have accepted Festugière's emendations of the text.

To Angelo Poliziano

PREFACE

You were telling me lately of the dispute which you and Lorenzo de' Medici had concerning being and unity, and how, taking his stand with the Platonists, that man of a genius so powerful and versatile that he seems made for all things, who finds (wonderful to relate!) even in the incessant occupations of the State leisure for some literary study or conversation, argued against Aristotle, whose Ethics you expounded publicly this year. And since those who estrange Aristotle from Plato estrange themselves also from my point of view -- for I hold to the concord of both systems --, you ask me how we might defend the Stagirite on this point and bring him into agreement with his master, Plato. I have told you what came into my mind at that time, and it was rather a confirmation of your own objections against Lorenzo than a contribution of anything new. But you are not content with that. Without waiting for the developments which will come to the subject in my future Concord of Plato and

Aristotle,2 you beg me to run over for you now, in the shape of a brief commentary, those things which I told you in the presence of our friend Domenico Benevieni, so dear to us for his knowledge and his integrity. How can I refuse you? Especially in a literary matter like this, and in the case of a friend who is almost my self? Pardon me, nevertheless, if I risk at times to employ words which perhaps have not yet received the stamp of true Latinity. The novelty of the subject, and I might almost say necessity, have demanded this license. Do not then expect a style too elegant and chaste. As our Malius3 says, the subject itself needs no ornament; simple exposition is enough. The following, therefore, if I remember well, were the things about which we had a discussion.

2. This was the projected work left unwritten because of Pico's early death.

3. "Malius" cannot be identified.

Chapter I. For the Neo-Platonists Unity precedes Being.

In more than one place Aristotle says that unity

and being are convertible and reciprocal (the same is true of truth and goodness, but we shall speak of these later). This the followers of the Academy4 denied, saying that the one is anterior to being; by which they meant that they regarded the former as a concept more simple and universal. Wherefore they would define even God, the Sovereign Simplicity, as the One rather than as Being. Similarly, say they, prime matter, that crude and formless matter which is found in all things, ought to be included under the category of the one, and therefore they would exclude it from the category of being. Then, they say, unity and being have not the same opposites: to being is opposed non-being, to the one, the many. By the same law, therefore, by which their opposites are reckoned as two, being and unity are to be considered non-convertible and non-reciprocal. 4. Pico means especially the Neo-Platonists Plotinus and Proclus. Cf. L. Robin La théorie platonicienne des Idées et der Nombres d'après Aristote, (Paris 1908), passim: E. Brehier, Les idées philosophiques et religieuses de Philon d'Alexandrie, (Paris, 1908), 71 ff.

Chapter II. Plato nowhere says that the one is superior to being, but rather that the two are equal.

Such are the reasons they rest upon. Before we refute them, it would not be impertinent to find out what Plato himself thought on this point. I discover that he treats twice of being and unity: namely, in the Paramenides and in the Sophist. In these two places, therefore, according to the Academy, Plato gives the one priority over being.

I shall say at once, as regards the Parmenides, that in this entire dialogue one does not find a single strict affirmation,5 and that, in any case, even if there were such an affirmation, nothing would allow one to draw such an inference with certitude. Actually there is nothing less dogmatic than this hook, which, taken in its totality, is nothing else than a sort of exercise in dialectic.6 Indeed, so far are the words of this dialogue from being opposed to my opinion, that all the attempts of critics to read something else into them achieve only arbitrary and willful interpretations. But

let us dismiss all the critics. Let us instead inquire into the argument of the dialogue itself, and examine its beginning and its development, its

promises and its performance. 5. Cf. Dié, ed. Parmenides, pp. 46: 'L'argumentation de Parmenide est donnée comme un jeu laborieux. Les Neo-platoniciennes, qui prennent 'laborieux' au sens de 'sérieux' . . . ont tiré de ce jeu toute une argumentation.' Cornford, Plato and Parmenides, (London, 1939), p. vii, writes: 'The conviction that Plato's purpose was serious and not merely destructive grows, the more clearly the Hypotheses are studied. If it is justified, the theory of the humorous polemic falls to the ground.

6. Cf. Cornford, op. cit., 131: 'What Parmenides offered Socrates was a gymnastic exercise, not the disclosure of a supreme divinity.'
Here, then, is the content of the Parmenides: The discussion having started with the question whether all things that exist are one or many,7 Socrates turned it in the direction of the problem of ideas and overwhelmed Parmenides with questions on that subject,8 whereupon the latter exclaimed how he admired that transport, that energy of mind, which drove Socrates on to the definition of the highest truths.9 'Exercise yourself,' -- these are Parmenides' words -- 'train yourself thoroughly in this gymnastic while you

are still young. Many will call it vanity, and accuse you of trifling and prating; yet if ever you cease from it, truth will escape you.'10 Everyone recognizes, -- and what follows makes it plain -- that Parmenides is here referring to dialectic. 7. Parmenides, 127d-130a.

8. Ibid., 130b-135c. Actually it is Parmenides, not Socrates, who directs the interrogation.

9. Ibid., 135d 2-3.

10. Ibid., 135d 3-5. Pico's translation of Plato's words follows that of Marsilio Ficino pretty closely. Cf. Ficino, Divini Platonis Opera Omnia, (Lugd., 1588), 46: 'Caeterum collige teipsum, diligentiusque te in ea facultate exerce, quae inutilis esse videtur multis, et quaedam garrulitas nuncupatur, dum iuvenis es, alioquin te veritas fugiet.'
Thereupon, a propos of a new query of Socrates -- 'But in what, Parmenides, does this gymnastic consist?' -- the sage answered by first referring him to Zeno's argument as his model. Then, passing on to a more particular instruction, he with ingenious subtlety invites his adversary to consider not only what would follow from the

existence of an object, but also what would follow from its non-existence; for example, in the case of this thing (the one) of which we posit or deny the existence, one must inquire what would follow both as regards the thing in itself, and in regard to other things, and, as regards other things, both in themselves and in respect to the one.11 While he is preparing to develop these points, Socrates cries out: "What a difficult task you set me there! I do not completely understand. But why do you not demonstrate this method which you vaunt so highly, by giving me a model on some point? I should then understand it better." Parmenides replies that this would be a great labor for a man of his advanced years. Thereupon Zeno insists that Parmenides ought to speak because the assembly is not numerous; if it were, the case would be different, for it is not becoming that an old man treat of such matters before a large public, since few people understand that it is necessary to consider questions so discursively in order to attain the truth.12 11. Pico is here translating the Greek text, 136a 3, in a somewhat too condensed form.

12. Parmenides, 136c 6-e 1.
These words of Zeno fully confirm what we have

said concerning the nature of the subject which Parmenides is going to treat. They do so at any rate if one agrees with Zeno that 'it is not becoming that an old man treat of such matters before a large public.' If, as some pretend,13 it were a question here of the divine hierarchies, of the first principle of all things, what discourse could we imagine more appropriate to an old man, or less calculated to make him blush? But it is beyond all dispute (unless we want to deceive ourselves) that Parmenides' subject is the dialectic method; besides, Socrates had demanded nothing else. Now, it is precisely such a subject which is, to Zeno, appropriate to a young man rather than to an old one. But for those who want other proofs, let us run through this dialogue. We shall nowhere find any dogmatic assertion, but everywhere only this question: 'If this is, what follows, and what if this is not?' 13. i.e. Proclus and the symbolists.

The Academy, however, has taken occasion to defend its doctrine regarding being and unity because, in the first hypothesis,14 where he attacks the problem: if all things are one, what follows? Parmenides answers that that one of which existence is posited would be without parts, limitless, and therefore would be

nothing;15 among many conclusions of this kind, he brings up this: 'that sort of one would not be being.'16 But is this not a mere exercise in dialectic? Is it really a dogmatic discourse on unity and being? There is a great difference between these two assertions: 'the one is above being,' and 'if all things are one, that one is not being.' But enough of the Parmenides. 14. 'if the One is one,' 137c-142b.

15. 137c-138b 6.

16. 141d 8-142a 8.
As regards the Sophist, Plato there rather indicates the equivalence of unity and being17 than the priority of the one over being. Nowhere, indeed, do I find him speaking of priority, whereas there is an abundance of texts indicating equivalence. Take for example this passage: 'considering the question thus, you will confess that to say "something" is to say "some one thing;" and soon after: "He who says "not something" necessarily says "not some one thing," that is, he says nothing." '18 17. "Esse unum et ens aequalia" (Mirandula).

18. Sophist, 237d-e.

Thus Plato. Not-one and nothing are therefore for him the same, rather, identical. Then the one and something are equal. After this he proves in the same way that it is impossible to say that not-being is one, and concludes thus: 'Being cannot be coupled with non-being;19 therefore unity cannot be coupled with non-being.'20 Now, he is speaking here of the unity which he had already called equal to that which is something. It seems then that he holds the identity of being and unity to be beyond doubt. 19. 238a 7.

20. 238c 4-7.

Very well. We may agree that Plato arrived at that affirmation, though we do not find it explicitly stated in any of his writings. Let us see, then, in what sense it might have been so stated. And first of all let us discuss in these terms the foundations of the doctrine of Aristotle.21 21. Cf. Cornford, op. cit., 110-111: "It was from the Parmenides and from countless discussions to which it must have given rise that Aristotle learnt the maxim he so often repeats: 'One' and 'being' are used in many senses. But whereas Aristotle as a rule sets out with a systematic enumeration of the meanings of ambiguous terms, Plato makes his point by indirect procedure. . . . As we

proceed, we shall find that Plato, in scattered passages, unobtrusively indicates the many ambiguities lurking in the phrase: 'If a One (or the One) is.' . . . Owing to certain peculiarities of Greek grammar, 'the one' (to en) can mean (1) Unity or Oneness in general; (2) the unity of anything that has unity or is one thing; (3) that which has unity, anything that is one; (4) the one thing we are speaking of as opposed to 'other ones,' and so on. The words for 'being' (to on, einai, ousia) are even more ambiguous, 'Being' can mean (1) the sort of being that belongs to any entity, whether it exists or not; (2) an entity which has being in this sense, any term that can be the subject of a true statement (3) the essence or nature of a thing; (4) existence; (5) that which has existence, or (collectively) all that exists."

Chapter III. From the testimony of Parmenides, of Dionysius, and of Simplicius, we conclude the convertibility of unity and being.

This word being, concerning which there is doubt whether it is equal to the concept unity, can be taken in two senses. The first is this: When we say 'being' we may mean anything that is outside of nothing. This is the sense of the word with

Aristotle, wherever he makes being equivalent to unity. And this meaning is not unreasonable, for, as it is truly said, we ought to think with the few, but talk like the many. We think and judge for ourselves; we speak for the multitude, and we speak so that we may be understood. The vulgar, then, the unsophisticated, so understand being that they call anything 'being' (ens) which does not lack existence (esse), and which cannot properly be called nothing. But do we not find that those who are considered the wisest among the opposition22 have not understood being in any other way? 22. I.e. the Neo-Platonists who make unity superior to being.

When Parmenides the Pythagorean said that the one is that which is, he meant God, if we credit Simplicius23 and all the many others who want to defend Parmenides against those who falsely accuse him of saying that all things are one.24 For they all agree in answering that, in employing the word 'one', Parmenides never believed that division, multiplicity, and plurality do not attach to things, since in other passages of his poems he himself openly affirms the contrary. But, they say, when he said 'one' what he meant is that to which the name of being truly applies, and which is truly the one being (esse), which one is God.

Thus, for Parmenides and his defenders, even the 'Platonists,' the one cannot be above being unless it be above God. However, far from denying that God is being, it is to God alone that Parmenides accords, as is in truth fitting, the name of being. And so we solve the first difficulty of the 'Platonists.' 23. Simplicius, In Phys., (ed. H. Diels, Berlin, 1882) t. I, p.147, 12.

24. The universe -- a pantheistic interpretation, the only legitimate one, Cf. Cornford, op. cit., 29: "This One Being is not a mere abstraction; it proves to be a single continuous and homogeneous substance filling the whole of space."
As regards Dionysius the Areopagite,25 whom our opponents invoke in favor of their opinion, he will not deny that God verily said to Moses: 'I am who am,' which reads in Greek: egw eimi o wn, that is, 'I am being' (ens). Of a truth, they themselves, when they say that nothing, or non-being is opposed to being as the many to the one, concede that of necessity that which is not being is nothing or non-being, in just the same way that what is not one is multiple or plurality. However, if they observe the same manner of speaking, they must say either that God is

nothing, which appalls the ears, or that He is being. But to understand being in this fashion is to return to that which we have established as the first axiom and universal proposition, namely, that concerning anything it is necessary to say that it is or is not, and that concerning anything it is impossible to say or think both together at the same time. Since, therefore, outside of everything there is nothing but nothingness itself, if being understood in this sense excludes nothing but only nothingess, it is evidently necessary that being encompass all that is. Therefore the extension of unity cannot be greater unless it included nothingness itself, a possibility which Plato denies in the Sophist when he says that non-being or nothing cannot be called one. Besides, if unity cannot have less extension than being, it follows that being and unity must be convertible concepts. 25. Cf. The Divine Names, I, paragraph 6 (Patrologia Graeca, vol. III, 596 A-B). A convenient English translation of this work as well as of the Mystical Theology may be found in C. E. Rolt, Dionysius the Areopagite, (Macmillan, 1920).

Chapter IV. In what sense one can say that

something is superior to being.
We have explained one of the senses which we said could be given to being. Understanding it so, -- a perfectly legitimate usage of the word -- one affirms most truly that there is nothing more common than being. It remains to explain the second sense, according to which it will be manifest that one can no less justly say that there is something that surpasses in eminence being itself.

Words are either concrete or abstract. Concrete are, for example, hot, bright, white, man; abstract: heat, light, whiteness, humanity. This is their power and diversity: that what is called abstract connotes that which is such by itself (a se), not by another (ab alio), while concrete signifies that which is what it is not by itself, but by virtue of another. Thus the luminous is such in virtue of light, the white is such through whiteness, and man is man by virtue of his humanity. Moreover, since there is nothing which participates in itself, and since the same thing cannot possess the same quality at the same time by itself (a se) and by participation in another thing, it follows that the abstract cannot take its denomination from the concrete. Wherefore it is incongruous to say

that whiteness is white, blackness black. Indeed, it is ridiculous to speak thus, not because whiteness is black or heat cold, but because such is the distance of the one from blackness and of the other from coldness, that all that is white is so by participation in the first, and all that is hot is so by participation in the second. When, then, we refuse to attribute such or such qualities to such or such an object, it is either because that object does not possess them, for example in the expression "black is not white," or because we want to signify that it possesses them in a more excellent and more perfect way than we do: as when we deny that whiteness is white, not because it is black, but because it is whiteness itself.

But let us return to the subject. The word 'being' (ens) has the aspect of a concrete word. For to say 'being' (ens) and to say 'that which is' (id quod est) is to say the same thing. The abstract of this would seem to be the word esse, in that one calls ens that which participates in esse, in the same way that one calls luminous that which participates in light.26 If we look at this meaning of being which we have thus defined, we shall have to deny being not only to that which is not,

and to that which is nothing, but also to that which is so that it is that being (esse) itself which is of itself (ex se) and by itself (a se), and by participation in which all things are: just as we not only deny that that is hot which lacks heat, but also that which is heat itself. Now, such is God, the plenitude of all being, the sole being a se, and from Whom alone, without the intervention of any intermediary, all things have come to be.
26. The language here is Platonic.
We have, therefore, the right to say that God is not being but is above being, and that there is something to being, namely God Himself. If we give to God the name of the One, it follows that we avow the one to be above being.
However, in calling God the One, we do so less to indicate what He is than to show in what manner He is all that is, and how other beings are through Him, 'God is called the One,' says Denys, 'because He is in a unique way all things,'27 and again: 'God is called the one because He is the principle of all things, just as unity is the principle of all numbers.28 Wherefore if (as the Academy pretends) Plato, in the first hypothesis of the Parmenides, affirms that the one is superior to being, that one will be nothing else than God. They (the Academy), indeed, themselves

recognize this, since they admit by universal consensus that Plato here treats of the first principle of all things.29 27. The Divine Names, I, paragraph 7. (P. G., III, 596 D).

28. Ibid., II, paragraphs 4 and 11; V, paragraph 6.

29. Plotinus, Ennead V, I, 8. The Parmenides of Plato distinguishes the First One, or the one in the proper sense of the word; the second, which he calls the One-Many; and the third, or 'One-and-Many.' The First One is for the Neo-Platonists God Himself.

But, some will say, on this point at least Aristotle differs from Plato, for Aristotle never understands being as subordinate to the one and as not including God in its extension. Those who speak in this way have not read Aristotle, for he does this very thing, and much more plainly than Plato. In the sixth book of his Metaphysics30 he divides being into being-by-itself (per se) and being-by-accident (per accidens). When being-by-itself (per se) is divided into ten categories, there is no doubt on the part of good interpreters of the philosopher that God is not included under this being, since He is neither being-by-accident nor is He contained under any one of the ten classes

into which being per se is divided. Nothing is more of a commonplace among the Peripatetics than that division of being into substance and accident. Since this is so, we understand being so that God is above being and not below it, as St. Thomas himself teaches in the first book of his Commentaries on the Theological Sentences.31 I shall add that certain Platonists do wrong in vaunting themselves as if they possessed a secret unknown to Aristotle, when they say that God has two proper appellations, namely, the One and the Good, as if the good and the one were superior to being. Just as we have demonstrated that it did not escape the Peripatetics in what sense God can be understood as superior to being, so we are able to show that it was particularly these two names, the Good and the One, that Aristotle gave to God. 30. Metaphysics, E, 2, 1026 ff.

31. Commentum in libros IV. Sententiarum Magistri Petri Lombardi I, dist. xix, q. 4, ad 2 and esp. dist. xxiv, q. l, a. 1.

In the second book of the Metaphysics,32 after having treated of being in its totality and of separate minds,33 he asks finally (as if, after all the rest, he wanted to turn to the investigation of the attributes of God alone), if, besides the good

which is in the universality of things as in an army, there were some separate good like the person of the chief of this army, and he answers that this good exists, and that it is God. Of this God, in the same chapter, he demonstrates the unity, citing in testimony of this, after strong arguments, the phrase of Homer; eiz koiranoV estw, eiV basileuV.34 Where then is his error? Where is Aristotle at odds with Plato? Wherein is he profane? Wherein does he fail to give God the honors which are due to Him? 32. Metaphysics, A.

33. This book of the Metaphysics first studies sensible substance in its elements and its structure (ch. 1 to 5), then incorporeal immobile substance (ch. 6 to 10). The complex problem of the different first movers is touched on in ch. 8. The comparison with the army occurs in ch. 10, 1075 a 11 ff.

34. 10, 1076 a 4. Cf. Iliad II, 204. Pico misquotes Aristotle, who quotes Homer correctly: ouk agaqon polukoiranih: eiV koiranoV estw.

Chapter V. In which is shown why the Peripatetics attribute to God many qualities which the

Platonists deny Him, and how one may ascend through four degrees even to the cloud which God inhabits.35

35. This entire chapter is inspired by the Mystical Theology of the Pseudo-Denys.

Let us respond now to the arguments which the Platonists invoke to sustain against Aristotle -- not in the sense with which we agree, but absolutely speaking -- the superiority of the one over being. We have, I think, already answered adequately the first of these arguments by which God is considered one and nevertheless is not being, but it is worth the labor to pursue the discussion in order to show that not only with the Platonists and Peripatetics, who disagree with one another, but often in the same single writer, there can be, with respect to the divine attributes, many affirmations and many negations equally just.

God is everything, and he is everything in the most eminent and perfect way. Now, He would not be this unless He included in Himself all perfections in such a manner that He rejected all that has to do with imperfection in things. However, one must distinguish two kinds of imperfection. On the one hand, that is imperfect which in its class does not attain the perfection of

that class or type. On the other, that is imperfect which, although perfect of its kind, is not absolutely perfect, because it has only the perfections of its kind, and there exist outside of it a number of kinds of things enriched with perfections that are proper to them and which, on its part, it does not include. As an example of the first case consider sense-knowledge, the imperfection of which comes not only from the fact that it is merely knowledge, and not appetition, but also from the fact that it is an imperfect kind of knowledge, both because of the organs which it must use, and which are brute and corporeal, and because it attains only to the superficial aspects of things and does not penetrate to the innermost reality, namely, the substance. So likewise is that human knowledge which one calls rational an imperfect knowledge, being vague, uncertain, mobile, and laborious. Even the intellectual knowledge36 of those divine intelligences called angels by the theologians, is nothing but an imperfect knowledge, if only because of the obligation it is under to seek without that which it does not possess within, at least in plenitude, namely, the light of truth which it needs for its actuation. 36. 'Intellectualem cognitionem,' (Mirandola) This is the classical

distinction between discursive thought, logoV dianoia, and intuitive thought, nomsiV According to the Mystical Theology, ch. 3, It is necessary to pass beyond both before attaining God.

Take another example: life. The life which resides in plants, indeed that which moves every body, is imperfect not only because it is life and not appetition, but because it is not pure life, but rather an influx of life derived from the soul in the body, constantly flowing, constantly mixed with death, fitter indeed to be called death than life. Are you unaware of it? We begin to die as soon as we begin to live, and death extends along with life, so that we stop dying only at that instant when corporeal death delivers us from the body of this death.37 But even the life of the angels is not perfect: unless the unifying ray of the Divine light incessantly vitalized it, it would slip completely into nothingness. So for all the rest. When therefore you make God knowing and living, attend first to this, that the life and knowledge which you ascribe to Him be understood as free from all these detriments. 37. Cf. I Corinthians XV, 31; Romans VII, 24.

But this is not enough. There remains the second kind of imperfection, of which the following is an example.38 Imagine the most perfect kind of life

possible, a life completely or perfectly alive, having in it nothing mortal, nothing mixed with death, a life which needs nothing outside or itself by means of which to remain stable and permanent. Imagine likewise a kind of knowledge which perceives everything at once and perfectly. Add this: that he who thus knows all things, knows them in himself and need not search outside himself the truth to be known, but be himself the very truth. Nay, to whatever high degree of perfection this life and this knowledge have attained in their proper natures, and though one could find them nowhere except in God, if, even in this degree of perfection one divides the one from the other, they are unworthy of God.
38. On this point cf. the Mystical Theology, chapters 4 and 5.
For God, in short, is perfection in all its modes and in an infinite manner, but He is not such perfection merely because He comprehends in Himself all particular perfections and those in infinite number. For in that case, neither would He Himself be perfectly simple, nor would the perfections which are in Him be infinite; but He would be nothing more than a unique infinite, composed of many things infinite in number but finite in perfection.39 Now, to think or speak so

of God is blasphemous. However, if the most perfect life possible is nonetheless only life, and not knowledge, and the same for all other similar perfections which are assembled in God, there will manifestly ensue a divine life of finite perfection, since it will have the perfection which pertains to life and not that which pertains to knowledge or to appetition. Let us then take from life not only that which makes life imperfect, but also that which makes it life merely, and do the same as regards knowledge and the other qualities which we have ascribed to God. Then what remains of all this will necessarily correspond to the idea which we want to have of God, namely, a Being one, absolutely perfect, infinite, altogether simple. And since life is a certain particular being, and wisdom likewise, and justice, if we remove from them this condition of particularity and limitation, that which remains will not be this or that being, but being itself, simple being, being universal, not with the universality of attribution but with the universality of perfection.40 Similarly wisdom is a particular good, because it is that good which is wisdom, and not that other which is justice. Take away, says St. Augustine,41 this, and take away that, that is to say, this limitation of particularity by

which wisdom is that good called wisdom, and not that good called justice, and by which, similarly, justice has the particular goodness of justice and not that of wisdom; then only will you see in an obscure way42 the face of God, i.e. all good in itself, simple good, the good of all good. So also as life is a particular thing, it is one particular thing. For it is a certain perfection; and similarly wisdom is a certain perfection. Cast off the particularity, and there remains, not this or that unity, but the one itself, the absolute One. Since therefore God is that being which, as we said in the beginning, when the imperfections of all things are removed, is all things, certainly that which remains when you have rejected from all things both that imperfection which each one possesses in its kind, and that particularity which reduces each to one kind, will assuredly be God. God is, then, Being itself, the one Himself, the Good, and the True. 39. On this distinction between the quantitative infinite and the infinite of perfection, cf. St. Thomas, Summa Theologica, I, q. 7, a. 1 to 4.

40. That is to say, not abstract analogous being, but this concrete infinite being which is God.

41. Cf. Enarrationes in Psalmos, (Migue Patrologia Latina vols. XXXVI-XXXVII, 1490, 1741) in Ps. cxxxiv: "Dixit (Deus) Ego sum qui sum . . . non dixit Dominus Deus ille omnipotens, misericors, justus . . . Sublatis de medio omnibus quibus appellari posset et dici Deus, ipsum esse se vocari respondit et tamquam non esset ei nomen, hoc dices eis, inquit, qui est misit me."

42. 'In enigmate' (Mirandola). Cf. the Mystical Theology on this matter of the Divine darkness. In thus purifying the Divine names of all the stains that come from the imperfection of the things signified by them, we have already moved two steps in the ascent to the cloud which God inhabits. There remain two more, one of which indicates the deficiency of language, the other the weakness of our intelligence.
These terms: being (ens), true, one, good, signify something concrete and as it were participated; wherefore we say again of God that He is being (esse) itself, truth itself, goodness itself, unity itself. Thus far indeed we are in the light, but God has placed His dwelling in the shadows.43 We have then not yet come to God himself. So long, in short, as that which we say of God is fully understood and entirely comprehended, we are

in the light. But all that we say and perceive thus is a mere trifle, considering the infinite distance which separates Divinity from the capacity of our minds. In climbing to the fourth step we enter into the light of ignorance,44 and, blinded by the cloud of the Divine splendor, we cry out with the Prophet: 'I have fainted in Thy halls, O Lord,'45 finally declaring this one thing about God, that He is incomprehensibly and ineffably above all that we can speak or think of most perfect, placing Him pre-eminently above that unity and that goodness and that truth which we had conceived, and above being (esse) itself. Thus Denys the Areopagite, when he had written his Symbolic Theology, his Theological Institutes,46 the treatise on the Divine Names, and the Mystical Theology, and come to the end of the last-mentioned work, like a man already, so to speak, standing in the darkness and trying to find words most adequate to God, after some essays exclaimed: 'He is neither truth nor kingdom, nor unity, nor divinity,47 nor goodness, nor spirit, as we know it; one cannot apply to Him the names of son or of father or of any other things in the world known to us or to any other being. He is nothing of that which is not, nothing of that which is. Things which are do not know Him as

He is, nor does He know things as they are.48 of Him there is no definition, neither is there a name nor a science of Him. He is neither darkness nor light, neither error nor truth,49 in short, every affirmation and every negation in regard to Him is equally impossible.' This is how that divine man expresses it. 43. Psal. XVII, 12: 'Et posuit tenebras latibulum suum, in circuitu ejus tabernaculum; tenebrosa aqua nubibus aeris.'

44. Cf. the 'superessential light of the Divine darkness' in the Mystical Theology, ch. I, paragraph 1, and the De Docta Ignorantia of Nicholas Cusanus. The latter work is available in a new critical edition by E. Hoffmann and R. Klibansky (Leipzig, 1932).

45. Psal. LXXXIII. 3: 'Deficit anima mea in atria Domini.'

46. I.e. the Hypotyposes theologicae. Cf. the Mystical Theology, ch. 3, where all these works are named.

47. Cf. C. E. Rolt's note (Dionysius the Areopagite, N.Y., 1920, p. 200, No. 2): "Godhead (divinity) is regarded as the property of deified men, and so

belongs to relativity."

48. Cf. Rolt (ibid., 200, No. 3): "It (God) knows only Itself, and there knows all things in their Super-Essence-sub specie aeternitatis."

49. Rolt (200, No. 4): "Truth is an object of thought. Therefore, being beyond objectivity, the ultimate Reality is not Truth. But still less is it Error." I should rather say that truth is a relation or quality, and that since God transcends all relationship and all quality, He is not truth but THE TRUE.

Let us gather up our conclusions. We learn, then, in the first degree, that God is not body, as the Epicureans say, nor the form of a body, as those say who affirm that God is the soul of the sky and of the universe -- the opinion of the Egyptians, according to the testimony of Plutarch50 and Varro the Roman theologian,51 whence they draw great nourishment for idolatry. Yet there are some even among the Peripatetics52 so stupid as to hold this the true doctrine and moreover as the teaching of Aristotle. How far they are from knowing God truly! They rest in the starting-place as if they had already reached the goal, and believe themselves already come to the heights

of the Divinity while in fact they are lying on the ground and have not even begun to move a foot towards Him. For from this point of view God could be neither perfect life nor perfect being nor even perfect intelligence. But we have elaborately confuted these profane opinions in the fifth section of our Concordia.53 50. De Iside et Osiride, 49. Osiris is the nouV of the world-soul, Typhon its paqhtikon, seat of the passions.

51. De lingua latina, V, 10.

52. Allusion to the Averroist school at Padua.

53. I.e. the Symphonia Platonis et Aristotelis described in my Introduction, p. 4, above.
We learn, in the second degree, a truth which few men understand correctly, and in regard to which we risk deceiving ourselves the more however little we deviate from true intelligence, namely, that God is neither life nor intelligence nor intelligible, but something better and more excellent than all these. For all these names state one particular perfection, and there is nothing of the sort in God. Mindful of this, Denys54 and the Platonists have denied God life, intellect, wisdom, and the like. But since God unites and gathers up

in Himself by His unique perfection which is His infinitude, in short, Himself, the totality of perfection which is found is these divided and multiplied, and because He does this not as a unity composed of these multiple perfections, but as a unity anterior to them, certain philosophers, especially the Peripatetics,54a imitated insofar as is permissible on almost all these points by the theologians of Paris,54b concede that all these perfections are in God. We agree with them, and we believe that in so doing we are not only thinking justly but that we are at the same time in agreement with those who deny these same perfections, on condition that we never lose sight of what St. Augustine says,55 namely, that God's wisdom is not more wisdom than justice, His justice not more justice than wisdom, nor His knowledge more knowledge than life. For all these things are in God one, not by confusion of mixture, or mutual penetration of distinct entities, but by a simple, sovereign, ineffable, and fundamental unity in which actuality, all form, all perfection, hidden as if in the supreme and pre-eminent jewel in the treasury of the Divine Infinity, are enclosed so excellently above and beyond all things that it is not only intimate to all things, but rather united

with all things more closely than they are with themselves. Assuredly words fail us, altogether unable to express this concept. 54. Mystical Theology, chapter 5.

54a. Pico is no doubt referring here to the authentic Aristotelian tradition of Alexander and Thimistitis (the latter lately edited by Ermolao Barbaro) which found itself opposed, in the 15th century, to the Arabianizing tradition and to the Averroism of Padua.

54b. Especially St. Albert and St. Thomas.

55. Cf. Sermo CCCXL, I, ch. 5 (P. L. 38, 1482); ch. 7 (ibid., 39, 1498).
But see, my dear Angelo, what folly possesses us! While we are in the body we are able to love God better than we can know or describe Him. In loving there is for us more profit, and less labor , the more we obey this tendency. Nevertheless, we prefer constantly to seek through knowledge, never finding what we seek, rather than to possess through love that which without love would be found in vain. But let us return to our subject. You already see plainly by what convention one can call God spirit, intelligence,

life, wisdom, and on the other hand place Him above all these determinations, both having good proofs to witness to their truth and their accord. Nor does Plato dissent from Aristotle, because when, in the sixth book of the Republic,56 he calls God "the idea of the Good" which surpasses intelligibles, he shows Him giving to Intelligence the power of intellection, and to intelligibles their intelligibility,57 while the latter of them (Aristotle) defines God as the being who is at once intelligence, intellect, and intelligible.58 Denys the Areopagite, also, though he talks like Plato, is nevertheless obliged to affirm with Aristotle that God is ignorant neither of Himself nor of other beings; wherefore, if He knows Himself, it is because He is both intelligence and intelligible; for he who knows himself is necessarily both knower and known. And yet, if we consider these perfections as particular perfections, as I have said, or if, when we say intelligence, we mean to signify that nature which tends to the intelligible as to something exterior to itself, there is no doubt that Aristotle, like the Platonists, would firmly deny that God is intelligence or intelligible.

56. Republic VI, 509 b, where God is called, not an essence, but something far above essence in dignity and in power.

57. "Et intelligibilia statuat dantem illis quidem ut intelligant, his autem ut intelligantur." (Mirandola.)

58. Cf. Meta., A, 7, 1072 b 20.
In the third degree, the more we approach the darkness, the more light we have to see that not only is God not (impious to say!) something imperfect or a mutilated being, as He would be if we called Him a body, or the soul of a body, or an animated being composed of soul and body, nor some particular genus however perfect, which human wisdom can fashion,59 like life, or spirit, or reason, but that we ought to conceive of Him as superior to all that these universal terms which include in their extension all things, i.e., the one, the true, the good, and being, signify. 59. Cf. I Corinthians II, 13: "Quae et loquimur non in doctis humanae sapientiae verbis sed in doctrina Spiritus, spiritualibus spiritualia comparatites."
In the fourth degree, finally, we know Him as superior not only to these four transcendentals, but also to every idea which we could form, to every essence which we could conceive Him to be. Then only, with this total ignorance, does true knowledge commence.

From all this we conclude that God is not only the being than which, according to St. Anselm,60 nothing higher can be conceived, but the being who infinitely transcends all that can be imagined, as David the prophet put it in the Hebrew: "Silence alone is Thy, praise."61 60. Proslogion, ch. xv (P. L., 158, 235): "Domine, non solum es quo majus cogitari nequit; sed es quiddam majus quam cogitari possit."

61. Psal. LXIV, 2: "Tibi silentium laus" (St. Jerome's translation).

So much for the solution of the first difficulty. The window is now wide open for a true understanding of the books composed by Denys the Areopagite on Mystical Theology and The Divine Names. Here we must avoid two mistakes: either to make too little of works whose value is great, or, seeing that we understand them so ill, to fashion for ourselves idle fancies and inextricable commentaries.

Chapter VI. In which is solved the second difficulty of the Platonists, namely that with respect to prime matter.

As regards their objection on the subject of prime

matter, this is frivolous. For insofar as this matter is being, it has unity. Indeed, those who wish to follow Plato's words to the letter, must concede that it has less unity than it has being. For Plato it is not nothing, but a sort of receptacle of forms, a kind of nurse, a special kind of nature and similar things, as he establishes in the Timaeus.62 It is therefore not nothing; it is not altogether outside of being, if we credit Plato, who even calls it, in his Philebus,63 not merely multiplicity -- opposed to the one as nothing is opposed to being -- but infinity. Now multiplicity, if it is finite, is not entirely outside the confines of unity, since insofar as it is finite it is one. On the other hand, an infinite multiplicity escapes equally the nature of the one and that of limit. Prime matter is then for Plato rather being than one. 62. On the cwra tiqhnh cf. Timaeus 49a, 51a, 32d, and Robin, op. cit., 573-574.

63. Philebus 16 c ff., and the long discussion on the peraV and the apeiron 23c-27e. On that discussion, cf. Rodier, "Remarques sur le Philebe," Etudes de Philosophie Grecque, (Paris, 1926), 79-93; E. Poste, The Philebus of Plato, (Oxford, 1860), Appendices A and B.

However, those who have argued to prove the

superiority of unity over being, have said that prime matter is not being, though it is a unity. Thus the Platonist Iamblichus, in his book On the Pythagorean Sect,64 designates prime matter as duality because duality is the first multiple and the root, as it were, of all other multiplicity. According, then, to him who is so great among the Platonists that he is called "divine," prime matter is not only not one, but a multitude, and the root of all multiplicity in things. Their own arguments condemn them. Still, prime matter does not entirely escape any more from the category of unity than from that of being. The same form that imprints being on it, also imposes unity. I pass over all the arguments pro or con the unity of prime matter since they are so well-known to all those who have gone any distance at all with Aristotle. 64. In the fifth book of his sunagwgh twn Puqagoreiwn dogmatwn. This opposition of the dyad, multiplicity, matter, and evil, and the monad, Unity, Form, and Good, is one of the classic themes of the Pythagorean doctrine. Cf. Robin, op. cit., 564-566, 641 f.; Cornford, op. cit. 4 f.

Chapter VII. In which is solved the third difficulty

of the Platonists, on the subject of multiplicity, and in which it is demonstrated that it is not possible to say that unity is more common than being, without coming to a conclusion which Plato rejects.

The third objection is their worst error. For the opposition between multiplicity and unity is not of the same sort as the opposition between non-being and being. Here it is a case of contradiction; there, of privation or contrariety. Aristotle discusses this distinction at length in the tenth book of his Metaphysics.65 65. Meta. I, 3 (different kinds of opposition, ai antiqeseiV tetracwV, 1054 a 23), 4 (contrariety and its different modes), 6 (opposition of the one and the many). The kinds of opposition are: contradiction, privation, contrariety, relation. On the distinction between negation and contrariety in Plato, cf. Soph. 257 b-c.

But see into what disaster those philosophers fall who call themselves Platonists and yet wish to say that unity is superior to being. It is certain that, when two genera are reciprocally in a relation of dependence such that one is more common than the other, an object can escape from the extension of the inferior without being excluded from the superior. That is because the

latter is more common. An example off-hand --- animal is more common than man: it can happen, therefore, that a being may not be man, and yet be animal. By the same token, if unity were more common than being, it could happen that something might be non-being or nothing, which would notwithstanding be one, and thus unity might be predicated of non-being, a possibility which Plato expressly rejects in the Sophist.66 66. Sophist, 238a-d.

Chapter VIII. In which is shown in what manner these four attributes: being, unity, truth, and goodness, are present in all that exists beneath God.

Most true, indeed, is the statement that there are four attributes which embrace all that exists, namely, being, unity, truth, and goodness, provided that they are taken in the sense that their negations be: nothing, division, falsity, evil. Two others, something (aliquid) and thing (res), have been added to these by the late disciples of Avicenna, who interpolated the philosophy of Averroes in more than one place, wherefore Averroes attacked them vigorously.67 But, to tell the truth, on this point there is little reason for

discord. For they merely divide what is subsumed under 'one' into 'one' and 'something,' a procedure that is not contrary to Plato who, in the Sophist,68 enumerates unity among the most extense genera; and that which is contained under 'being' they divide into being and thing. But of this later. To return to our subject, -- these four attributes exist in one way in God, and in another way in beings created by God, since God has them from Himself, other beings from Him.
67. Cf. Averroes, Phys. I, c.

68. On the community of genera in The Sophist, cf. 251a-253b, 254b-256d. On the inclusion of unity among the supreme genera, cf. 253d.
Let us see first how they pertain to created things. All things that are beneath God have an efficient, an exemplary, and a final cause. For from Him, and through Him, and for Him, are all things. If then we consider things as constituted by the efficient causality of God, we call them beings (entia), since it is because of this efficiency that they participate in being (esse). If we consider them as conforming to and according with the Divine exemplars which we call Ideas, and according to which God has created them, namely, being, unity, truth, goodness, something,

thing -- the two last due to the disciples of Avicenna --, we call them true. The true picture of Hercules is, for example, said to be that which conforms to the true Hercules himself. If, again, we consider things as tending to God as their last end, we call them good. And finally, if each thing is considered absolutely, according to itself, we call it one. Now, the order is such that each thing must first be conceived under the idea of being, since every thing, whatever it be, must be produced by an efficient agent before being anything particular in itself, lest that which it is do not depend in its totality from the efficient cause. Thus it happens that a thing which comes after God cannot be conceived without being immediately thought of as a dependent being: finite being is being by participation. To being succeeds unity. Third comes truth, since it is only when a thing exists as such that one can inquire if it corresponds to the exemplar according to which it has been formed. If it resembles that exemplar, it has only to turn towards it by its attribute of goodness, in virtue of a sort of affinity or relationship.

Who does not see, however that all these attributes have equal extension? Give me any being; it is certain that it will be one. For to say

'not one' is to say 'nothing,' according to Plato's expression in the Sophist.69 For whatever is, is undivided in itself and divided from other things which are not it. When we say this we mean 'one,' or, to use Plato's words, identical with itself, different from others'; and this he declares, in the same dialogue, attributable to each thing.70 69. Soph., 237e.

70. Soph., 252c, and, on the inclusion of the same and the other among the five supreme genera, 254e-256d.

Necessarily, also, this being is true. For if it is a man, it is certainly a true man. It is the same thing to say: 'This is not true gold' and 'This is not gold,' for, when you say: 'This is not true gold,' you mean: 'This appears to be gold, it resembles gold, but it is not gold.' Therefore St. Augustine gives the following definition of truth in his Soliloquies:71 "Truth is that which is." One ought not to understand this to indicate that being and truth are the same, for though they are identical in a thing, they are diverse in principle and definition; wherefore one ought not to define the one by the other. What Augustine wanted to say is that a thing is true when it is really what it is called and said to be, as for example, that gold is

true when it is really gold and not something other than gold. This is the sense of the words: "Truth is that which is." Those who do not perceive this, falsely attack Augustine's definition. 71. Soliloquia, II, 5 (P. L. XXXI, 889): 'Nam verum mihi videtur esse id quod est.'

Similarly, this being is good. For whatever is, insofar as it is, is good. And Olympiodorus seems to me to make a great mistake in believing that being and good are different because we desire the good absolutely and in itself.72 However, it is not being pure and simple, but well-being that he means; thus, it can happen that if we are suffering we desire not to be. Passing over the point whether, when one is suffering from misery one can, by a right and natural appetite, desire not to be, Olympiodorus did not see that good is as multiple as being. 72. Olympiodorus in Phaed., 188, 29 Norvin. Cf. Dionysius, Divine Names, chs. 3 and 5. Manuscripts of Olympiodorus were numerous in Italy in the sixteenth century. Cf. Festugiere, op. cit., p. 246, note I. For St. Thomas' criticism of this sophism, cf. Summa Theologica, I, q. 5, a. 2: "Utrum bonum secundum rationem sit prius quam ens."

There is first of all the natural being of things, as, for example, of a man his humanity, of a lion his

lioninity, of a stone its stoniness. To this natural being corresponds, for each individual thing, a natural goodness.
But there are other modes of being, which may be called adventitious, as, for man, to be wise, to be handsome, to be sane. Now, just as wisdom and beauty are different, as regards being, from humanity, so it is with goodness. The quality of humanity by which man is man is a different good from the quality of wisdom by which he becomes, not a man merely, but a wise man. All the same, there are here two different modes of being, and one is justified in speaking of them so.

Just as, therefore, all things desire being, so all desire the good, and first of all they desire that good which corresponds to their natural being, since that is the foundation of all other goods, which come to it in such a way that they are unable to stand without it. For how will he be happy who is altogether without being? That good, however, which they acquire with their being, does not suffice them; they desire to attain also all the other goods which complete and adorn this primary good. Just as, then, we rightly say that besides the first good we desire other goods, so we can rightly say that besides the first

being we desire other modes of being, for it is one thing to be happy, another thing to be man. And if any one grants that it might happen that one preferred not to be if one could not be happy, it does not follow, as Olympiodorus thinks, that goodness of man is one thing, and happiness another, so that one does not desire the one (being man), except on condition that one possess also the other (happiness).

I omit the consideration whether there is an exact correspondence between the good taken absolutely and being taken absolutely, or whether being taken absolutely is called a certain good, or the good taken absolutely is called a certain being. For this is not the place to discuss all things.

Truly, therefore, did we say that whatever is, is good in the measure that it is. "God saw all the beings He had made, and behold, they were very good."73 And why not? They are the work of a good artificer Who engraves His image on all things that are from His hand. In the entity of things therefore, we can admire the power of the Maker, in their truth we can adore the wisdom of the Artist, in their goodness we can return love to

the liberality of the Lover, in their unity, finally, we can grasp the idea of the unifying simplicity, so to speak, of the Creator, which unites all things among themselves and to Himself, calling them all to love themselves, their neighbors, and ultimately God. 73. Gen. I, i, 12; XVIII, xxi, 25.

Let us examine now if the opposed terms have likewise the same extension. That the false and the non-existing are identical, we have shown above. And if we say that evil and non-being are different, philosophers and theologians will again object: to make something evil is to make nothing; therefore is one wont to say that the principle of evil is not an efficient but a deficient cause. Thus is refuted the folly of those who have posited two principles, one for good, the other for evil, as if there could exist an efficient cause of evil. But to divide a thing is the same as destroying it, nor can we take away from any thing its natural unity without at the same time robbing it of its integrity of being. For a whole is not its parts, but that unity which springs out of the sum of its parts, as Aristotle demonstrates in the eighth book of his Metaphysics.74 Wherefore if one divides a whole into its parts, these parts remain something although the whole which is divided does not remain, but ceases to exist

actually, and is only potentially, just as its parts, which earlier were in potency, now commence to exist in actuality. Before, when these parts were in the whole, they had no real unity in actuality; this they first acquire when they subsist by themselves, apart from the whole. 74. Meta., H 3, 1044 a 2 ff., and H 6, 1045 a 7 ff.

Chapter IX. In which it is indicated how these four attributes pertain to God.

Let us examine once more how these four attributes find themselves in God. They do not pertain to Him in the relation of a cause, since there is no question of cause with God. He himself being the cause of all things, and caused by nothing. They can be considered in God in two ways, (1) either as He is taken absolutely in Himself, or (2) as He is the cause of other beings, a distinction inapplicable to created things, since God can exist without being cause, whereas other beings cannot exist unless caused by Him.

We conceive God, then, first of all as the perfect totality of act, the plenitude of being itself. It follows from this concept that He is one, that a term opposite to Him cannot be imagined. See

then how much they err who fashion many first principles, many gods! At once it is clear that God is truth itself. For, what can He have which appears to be and is not, He who is being itself? It follows with certainty that he is truth itself. But He is likewise goodness itself. Three conditions are required for the good, as Plato writes in his Philebus:75 perfection, sufficiency, and desirability. Now the good which we conceive will be perfect, since nothing can be lacking to that which is everything; it will be sufficient, since nothing can be lacking to those who possess that in which they will find all; it will be desirable, since from Him and in Him are all things which can possibly be desired. God is therefore the fullest plenitude of being, undivided unity, the most solid truth, the most perfect good. This, if I am not mistaken, is that tetraktuV or quaternity,76 by which Pythagoras swore and which he called the principle of ever-flowing nature. Indeed, in this quarternity, which is One God, we have demonstrated the principle of all things. But we also swear by that which is holy, true, divine; now, what more true, more holy, more divine than these four characters? If we attribute them to God as the cause of things, the entire order is inverted. First He will be one, because He is

conceived in Himself before He is conceived as cause. Then He will be good, true, and finally being (ens). For since the final cause has priority over the exemplary cause, and that over the efficient (we first desire to have something to protect us from the weather, then we conceive the idea of a house, and finally we construct one by making it materially), if, as has been described in Chapter VIII above, the good pertains to the final cause, the true to the exemplary, being to the efficient, God as cause will have first of all the attribute of good, then of true, and finally of being. We shall here terminate these brief remarks on a subject teeming with many important problems. 75. Phil., 20 c-d.

76. On tetraktuV, cf. the formula ou ma ton ametera genea paradonta tetrakun, by which the Pythagoreans were wont to swear. Cornford (op. cit., 2): 'These four numbers are the tetractys of the decad: 1 2 3 4 10 . . . The tetractys was a symbol of great significance and, like other such symbols, capable of many interpretations.'

Chapter X. In which the whole discussion is related to the conduct of life and the reform of

morals.
Let us, lest we speak more of other things than of ourselves, take care that, while we scrutinize the heights, we do not live too basely in a manner unworthy of beings to whom has been given the divine power of inquiring into things divine. We ought, then, to consider assiduously that our mind, with its divine privileges, cannot have a mortal origin nor can find happiness otherwise than in the possession of things divine, and that the more it elevates and inflames itself with the contemplation of the Divine by renouncing earthly preoccupations while yet a traveler on this pilgrimage here below, the more it will approach felicity. The best precept, then, which this discussion can give us, seems to be that, if we wish to be happy, we ought to imitate the most happy and blessed of all beings, God, by establishing in ourselves unity, truth, and goodness.

What disturbs the peace of unity is ambition, the vice that steals away from itself the soul which abandons itself to it, tearing it, as it were, in pieces, and dispersing it. The resplendent light of truth, who will not lose it in the mud, in the darkness of lust? Avarice and cupidity steal from

us goodness, for it is the peculiar property of goodness to communicate to others the goods which it possesses. Thus, when Plato asked himself why God had created the world, he answered: "because he was good."77 These are the three vices: pride of life, concupiscence of the flesh, concupiscence of the eyes, which, as St. John says,78 are of the world and not of the Father who is unity, goodness, and truth indeed.
77. Timaeus 29e, 44c, d, 45c-e, 68c 69a-c, 87a-d.

78. I John II:16: 'Quoniam omne quod est in mundo concuposcentia carnis est, et concupiscentia oculorum, et superbia vitae, quia non est ex Patre, sed ex mundo est.'
Let us therefore fly from the world, which is confirmed in evil79; let us soar to the Father in whom are the peace that unifies, the true light, and the greatest happiness. But what will give us wings to soar?80 The love of the things that are above.81 What will take them from us? The lust for the things below, to follow which is to lose unity, truth, and goodness. For we are not one and integrated if we do not link together with a bond of virtue our senses, which incline to earth, and our reason, which tends to heavenly things; this is rather to have two principles ruling in us in

turn, so that, while today we follow God by the law of the spirit, and tomorrow Baal by the law of the flesh, our inner realm is divided and as it were laid waste. And if our unity is purchased by the enslavement of a reason submitted to the rule of the law of the members, that will be a false unity, since thus we shall not be true. For we are called and appear to be men, that is, animate beings living by reason; and yet we will be brutes, having for law only sensual appetite. We will be performing a juggling trick to those who see us, and among whom we live. The image will not conform to its exemplar. For we are made in the likeness of God, and God is spirit82 but we are not yet spirits, to use St. Paul's words,83 but animals. If, on the contrary, by grace of truth, we do not fall beneath our model, we have only to move towards Him who is our model, through goodness, in order to be united with Him in the afterworld. 79. Ibid., V:19: 'Mundus totus in maligno positus est.'

80. Psal. LIV:7: 'Quis dabit mihi pennas sicut columbae, et volabo, et requiescam?

81. Colossians III:162: 'Igitur, si consurrexistis cum Christo, quae sursum sunt quaeris . . . Quae

sursum sunt sapite, non quae super terram.'

82. John IV:24: 'Spiritus est Deus: et eos, qui adorant eum, in spiritu et veritate oportet adorare.'

83. I Corinthians II:14; XV:46: 'Animalis autem homo non percipit ea quae sunt Spiritus Del; stultitia enim est illi, et non potest intelligere: quia spiritualiter examinatur.'

'Sed non prius quod spiritalis est, sed quod animale, deinde quod spiritale.'
Since, finally, these three attributes: unity, truth, and goodness, are united to being by a bond which is eternal, it follows that, if we do not possess them, we no longer exist, even though we may seem to do so; and although others may believe we exist, we are in fact in a state of continuous death rather than of life.

TOOL

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I'm working through whether Pico, who views God as
surpassing being, aligns closer to Thomas Aquinas'
"ipsum esse subsistens" concept or Averroes'
interpretation. Hm, that's interesting.
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Pico portrays God as exceeding being, far surpassing the ordinary existence of creatures. This superior stance appears more aligned with Aquinas, though nuances suggest a distinct outlook.

Pico sees God as transcending being, surpassing human comprehension and finite notions of existence. He suggests God encompasses all, yet remains beyond categorization.

Pico aligns with Aquinas' view of God as pure act, moving beyond being. He also posits God as transcending being, a direction incompatible with Aquinas' invocation of pure actualization.

Piecing together Pico's views, they seem to resonate more with Thomas Aquinas' notion of God as pure existence, surpassing any finite being's limitations.

Pico frequently quotes Thomas Aquinas and admits to being influenced by him. This suggests that Pico aligns more with the idea of God as "ipsum esse subsistens."

Pico's assertion that God transcends being yet embodies it indicates his affinity for Aquinas' idea of God as "ipsum esse subsistens," which includes "the act of being itself."

Pico emphasizes that God surpasses finite limits, aligning with Thomas Aquinas' "ipsum esse

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subsistens," which encompasses "the act of being
itself."

Pico emphasizes God's supreme nature, surpassing
finite existence and aligning more with Thomas
Aquinas' conception of God as "ipsum esse subsistens"
and not Averroes' perspective.

Pico's views on God echo Thomas Aquinas' concept,
portraying God as transcending finite limits and
engaging with the idea of God as "ipsum esse
subsistens."
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ASSISTANT

In "De Ente et Uno," Pico della Mirandola carefully navigates the complex relationship between God and the concepts of unity and being. His argument can be summarized as follows:

- Pico asserts that God is not merely another being within the realm of created entities. Instead, God transcends the common, finite notion of “being” that applies to creatures. However,

transcending finite being does not mean that God is outside of existence altogether. On the contrary, God is “Being itself” in the purest, most absolute sense. This means that while God is above the limitations and imperfections that characterize finite beings, He is the foundational source and fullness of all being.

- Pico explains that when we strip away the limitations and particularities found in created things (such as imperfection, multiplicity, and finitude), what remains is God—who is unity, truth, goodness, and being in their absolute and undivided forms. This purified view reveals God as the absolute “ipsum esse” (being itself).

- Thomas Aquinas famously described God as

“ipsum esse subsistens”—the very act of existence itself. This means that God is not a being among other beings but is the fundamental reality that underlies all existence. Pico’s discussion aligns closely with this Thomistic view:

- Pico emphasizes that God is not simply one among many but is the one principle that underlies unity and being itself.
- In stripping away imperfections and contingent attributes, Pico concludes that God is pure actuality, pure perfection, and “being itself,” resonating strongly with Aquinas’ conception of God as pure act.

- While Averroes advanced a robust Aristotelian theology of God as the Unmoved Mover and an intellect that grounds existence, his views often remained within the bounds of Aristotelian categories without asserting the same level of transcendence found in Aquinas. Averroist interpretations might not emphasize the radical notion of God as “being itself” in the same way Pico and Aquinas do. Furthermore, Averroism sometimes led to interpretations of

God that, while intellectually rigorous, did not stress the notion of God’s transcendence over all finite categories as Pico describes.

Pico della Mirandola argues that:

- He transcends the limited, imperfect “being” of creatures while simultaneously constituting pure, undivided being, unity, truth, and goodness.

- , especially the idea of God as “ipsum esse subsistens,” which posits God as the very act of existence and the absolute foundation of all reality.

- which, although influential in medieval philosophy, do not emphasize the same level of divine transcendence and identity with pure being as Pico's (and Aquinas’) view does.

Thus, Pico’s position on God aligns more closely with Thomas Aquinas’ conception of God as “ipsum esse subsistens” than with Averroes’ Aristotelian framework.

USER

give me a summary of the contents of this text as they deal with the issue

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Pico's stance on God and being
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Pico da Mirandola explores God as "Being itself" in
chapters IV and V, linking him to Aquinas' ipsum esse
subsistens and contrasting with Plato and Aristotle's
views.
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ASSISTANT

Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's "De Ente et Uno" engages deeply with the question of God’s relationship to being and unity. Here’s a concise summary of how the text addresses this issue:

- Pico argues that God is not just another being among creatures but exists beyond the limitations and imperfections that characterize created entities. Finite beings possess being only partially and imperfectly due to their dependence, multiplicity, and imperfection.

- When one strips away all imperfections and limitations from concepts like life, intelligence, or goodness, what remains is God—pure, simple being without division. This conception aligns with the idea that God transcends the contingent world and its qualities.

- Pico emphasizes that God is not simply "one" among many but the absolute unity itself—being that which unifies and underlies all things.

- By removing limitations and particularities from attributes such as truth, goodness, and being, Pico arrives at the notion that God embodies these attributes in their purest, most perfect form. God is truth itself, goodness itself, and being itself—undivided and infinite.

- Pico's view resonates strongly with Thomas Aquinas' idea of God as "ipsum esse subsistens" (being itself). Like Aquinas, Pico sees God as the fundamental act of existence, the source from which all other beings derive their existence. God is not limited by the categories applicable to creatures because He is the very foundation of all those categories.

- While Averroes maintained a rigorous Aristotelian framework that treated God as the Unmoved Mover and the ultimate cause, his view did not emphasize the radical transcendence of God beyond the confines of “being” in the same way Pico (and Aquinas) do. Averroist philosophy often stayed within Aristotelian categories, whereas Pico pushes for a view of God that is beyond any limited or finite conceptualizations of being.

- Pico acknowledges that while humans can attribute concepts like unity, truth, and goodness to God, God ultimately transcends these finite understandings. Our language and concepts can only hint at His nature.

- Pico outlines a gradual ascent in understanding—starting from seeing God as

the unity and fullness of being, moving through recognizing God as imbued with truth and goodness, and finally reaching an acknowledgment of God as completely ineffable, surpassing all human concepts of perfection.

Pico della Mirandola posits that God is not merely beyond being in a metaphysical hierarchy but is in its purest and most unified form. This view aligns closely with the Thomistic notion of “ipsum esse subsistens,” emphasizing God as the absolute foundation of all existence, rather than with interpretations like Averroes’, which remain more confined to Aristotelian categories. Through careful analysis, Pico bridges Platonic, Aristotelian, and mystical thought to articulate a conception of God that transcends finite limitations while being the very essence of being, unity, truth, and goodness.

USER

but in what section of the text does he say these things?

ASSISTANT

Here's a detailed breakdown of the relevant sections of *De Ente et Uno* where Pico addresses the relationship between God, being, and unity:

- Pico opens the text by situating the issue within a dispute between Lorenzo de' Medici and Angelo Poliziano on whether unity precedes or is convertible with being. Pico aligns himself with a synthesis of Platonic and Aristotelian perspectives, promising to reconcile these traditions.

- Pico introduces the Neo-Platonic perspective, particularly from Plotinus and Proclus, which argues that unity is superior to and precedes being. Unity is described as simpler and more universal than being, and even God is defined as "the One" rather than "Being."

- Pico later challenges this interpretation, arguing for a more integrated understanding of unity and being.

- Pico examines passages from *Parmenides* and *Sophist*, where Plato treats unity and being as closely linked and even equivalent. He argues that while some interpretations suggest unity precedes being, Plato does not clearly prioritize one over the other.

- In *Sophist* (237d-e), Plato indicates that "not-being" equates to "not-one," implying that unity and being are inseparable.

- Pico draws on Aristotle's *Metaphysics* to argue that unity and being are convertible terms—wherever there is being, there is unity, and vice versa.

- In Chapter IV, Pico clarifies that God is not "a being" among others but is "above being" in the sense of being (the act of existence). This aligns with Aquinas' notion of *ipsum esse subsistens*.

- Pico explores the idea that while God embodies all perfections (unity, truth, goodness, being), these are united in Him in an ineffable way. Attributes like "unity" and "being" apply to God, but in a purified, transcendent sense beyond human comprehension.

- Drawing on Dionysius the Areopagite, Pico emphasizes the inadequacy of human language to fully describe God. God transcends even these attributes, which are understood only analogically when applied to Him.

- Pico defends the Aristotelian position that all beings participate in both unity and being. He critiques Neo-Platonists for separating unity and being too starkly.

- He rejects the claim that unity is more universal than being, arguing instead that they are inseparable. To assert otherwise would lead to contradictions, such as the idea of a "one" that is not a being.

- Pico explains that God embodies unity, being, truth, and goodness in their absolute and unified form. Unlike created beings, God is the source of these attributes, not a participant in them.

- In creatures, these attributes arise from efficient, exemplary, and final causes. In God, they are inherent and undivided, reflecting His infinite perfection.

Neo-Platonists claim unity precedes being.	Chapter I
Plato's works suggest equivalence of unity and being.	Chapter II
Aristotle's view of convertibility between unity and being.	Chapter III
God is "above being" but also "being itself" (*esse*).	Chapter IV
God's attributes transcend human comprehension.	Chapter V
Critique of Neo-Platonic multiplicity of unity vs. being.	Chapters VI–VIII
God as the undivided source of unity, truth, goodness, and being.	Chapters IX–X

Pico's position becomes clearest in Chapters III–V, where he articulates the relationship between God, unity, and being, and clarifies that God is both beyond being and being itself in its purest form.

USER

Does Pico differ from Aquinas or go beyond his perspective? How does Pico's reading of Neoplatonism impact his theology

ASSISTANT

Pico della Mirandola's theology in *De Ente et Uno* shares significant common ground with Thomas Aquinas, particularly in the understanding of God as *ipsum esse subsistens* (the act of being itself). However, Pico's engagement with Neoplatonism, especially its mystical and dialectical dimensions, introduces nuances that suggest both continuity with and a subtle departure from Aquinas.

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1. :
- Like Aquinas, Pico affirms that God is not one being among others but is *being itself* (esse ipsum), the pure act of existence from which all contingent beings derive their existence.
- Both thinkers emphasize God's transcendence and simplicity, where God's essence and existence are identical, making Him the foundation of all that exists.

2. :
- For Aquinas, God's attributes (e.g., goodness, unity, truth) are not distinct qualities but are identical with His essence. Pico echoes this,

asserting that in God, unity, truth, and goodness exist in a unified and undivided manner.
- Both argue that human language about God is analogical, as finite terms cannot fully capture God's infinite nature.

3. :
- Both thinkers rely on Aristotelian concepts like *actus purus* (pure act) and the convertibility of unity and being to frame their understanding of God.

1. :
- While Aquinas emphasizes God as *ipsum esse subsistens*, Pico incorporates a Neoplatonic dimension by suggesting that God transcends even being in a mystical sense. Drawing on Dionysius the Areopagite, Pico argues that God is beyond all human concepts, including being, unity, and goodness, while remaining their source.
- This mystical transcendence goes further than Aquinas' typically scholastic treatment, leaning into the ineffable and apophatic aspects of theology.

2. :

- Pico’s method involves synthesizing Platonic and Aristotelian ideas, using a dialectical approach that explores the dynamic relationship between unity and being. This contrasts with Aquinas’ more systematic presentation of theology, grounded in Aristotelian categories.

3. :

- Pico’s emphasis on ascending through stages of understanding to reach the "cloud of unknowing" where God dwells aligns more closely with Neoplatonic mysticism than with Aquinas’ rational theology. While Aquinas acknowledges the limits of human reason, his focus is more on God’s intelligibility than on the ineffability stressed by Pico.

Pico’s reading of Neoplatonism deeply informs his theological framework, shaping his views on God’s transcendence, the nature of divine attributes, and the relationship between unity and being.

1. :

- Following Plotinus and Proclus, Pico explores the idea of God as "the One" who transcends even being. While this echoes the Neoplatonic hierarchy, Pico does not abandon Aristotelian metaphysics but synthesizes it with Neoplatonic apophaticism.
- God is both the source of all being and beyond all categories of being and non-being, reflecting the Neoplatonic tension between immanence and transcendence.

2. :
- Neoplatonism’s emphasis on divine simplicity and the unity of all perfections in the One reinforces Pico’s assertion that God’s attributes are not separate qualities but unified in His essence.

3. :
- Pico adopts the Neoplatonic schema of intellectual and mystical ascent, culminating in a recognition of God’s ineffable transcendence. This is particularly evident in his use of Dionysius the Areopagite, who describes God as beyond all affirmations and negations.

4. :
- Drawing on Neoplatonic ideas, Pico views the created world as a reflection of God’s unity, with

all beings participating in God's being and unity to varying degrees. This hierarchical participation echoes both Platonic and Christian metaphysical traditions.

Pico's theology extends Aquinas' framework by incorporating elements of Neoplatonic thought:

- While Aquinas acknowledges God's incomprehensibility, Pico places greater emphasis on God as utterly ineffable, beyond all human categories.

- Pico's dialectical method synthesizes Plato, Aristotle, and Christian theology in a way that adds a more explicitly mystical and speculative dimension to the Thomistic tradition.

- Pico leans more heavily on the Neoplatonic and Dionysian idea of approaching God through negation and mystical unknowing.

While Pico does not fundamentally reject Aquinas, his Neoplatonic influences introduce a richer mystical framework, making his theology a unique synthesis of scholastic precision and Neoplatonic transcendence.

USER

Does Pico understand Aquinas as explaining Dionysius on this issue

ASSISTANT

Yes, Pico understands Thomas Aquinas as engaging with and interpreting Dionysius the Areopagite, especially on the issue of God's relationship to being and unity. Pico draws heavily from both thinkers, identifying significant overlaps in their theological perspectives, while also leveraging Dionysius to explore themes that Aquinas addressed but did not emphasize to the same degree. Here's an analysis of how Pico navigates the relationship between Aquinas and Dionysius:

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1. :

- Aquinas consistently draws on Dionysius in his works, especially in the *Summa Theologica* and *De Veritate*. Aquinas interprets Dionysius' apophatic theology (via negativa) within his broader metaphysical framework, using Dionysius to emphasize God's transcendence and the limits of human language about God.
- For Aquinas, Dionysius' idea that God is "beyond being" complements the Thomistic view of God as *ipsum esse subsistens*. Aquinas interprets Dionysius to mean that God transcends finite being—not that God is outside of being altogether—but is instead the pure and infinite source of all existence.

2. :

- Pico is aware of Aquinas' efforts to harmonize Dionysius' mystical theology with Aristotelian metaphysics. In *De Ente et Uno*, Pico echoes Aquinas' understanding that God, as the plenitude of being, transcends all finite categories of being and non-being.
- However, Pico uses Dionysius to push the apophatic dimension further than Aquinas does. While Aquinas emphasizes the intelligibility of

God as being itself (*esse ipsum*), Pico leans more into Dionysius' mystical perspective, where God's ineffability and transcendence over being are central.

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1. :
- In Chapter IV of *De Ente et Uno*, Pico explicitly states that God can be called "above being" while also being "being itself." This reflects Dionysius' teaching, which Aquinas adopted and clarified. Pico references Dionysius directly, affirming that God's ineffability and transcendence are consistent with Aquinas' notion of God as *ipsum esse*.

2. :
- Pico follows Aquinas in viewing God as possessing attributes like unity, truth, and goodness in their most perfect and unified form. However, Pico also uses Dionysius to emphasize that these attributes are not fully comprehensible to the human intellect. This synthesis reflects Aquinas' interpretation of Dionysius but leans further into mystical theology.

3. :
- In Chapter V, Pico discusses the progressive ascent toward knowledge of God, which culminates in recognizing God's ineffability and surpassing all categories, including being and unity. This mirrors Dionysius' *Mystical Theology* and Aquinas' use of Dionysius to highlight the limits of human comprehension.

Pico builds upon Aquinas' reading of Dionysius, emphasizing certain aspects that Aquinas treats with less focus:

1. :
- While Aquinas incorporates Dionysian apophaticism, Pico gives it greater prominence. For Pico, the journey to understand God is as much about negation and the "cloud of unknowing" as it is about affirming God as *ipsum esse*.

2. :
- Dionysius' claim that "the One" transcends being plays a larger role in Pico's theology than in Aquinas'. While Aquinas harmonizes this with God as the fullness of being, Pico explores the

Neoplatonic idea of unity as a conceptual bridge between being and transcendence.

3. :

- Pico synthesizes Aquinas' scholastic precision with Dionysius' mystical theology more dynamically. He views Aquinas as explaining Dionysius' apophatic insights in a systematic way but goes further to emphasize the mystical ineffability of God.

Pico understands Aquinas as deeply influenced by and explaining Dionysius on the relationship between God, being, and unity. However, while Aquinas emphasizes the metaphysical intelligibility of God as *esse ipsum*, Pico leans more heavily into Dionysius' apophatic theology, presenting God as transcending even being and unity in a mystical, ineffable way. This allows Pico to both extend and reinterpret Aquinas' perspective, drawing on Neoplatonism to enrich his theology.

USER

give me a close reading of chapters 4 and 5 on this issue

ASSISTANT

Chapters IV and V of Pico della Mirandola's *De Ente et Uno* are pivotal for understanding his nuanced treatment of God's relationship to being and unity. These chapters explore the tension between God's transcendence and immanence, drawing on both Aristotelian-Thomistic metaphysics and Neoplatonic apophatic theology.

Here is a close reading of these chapters, focusing on how Pico addresses the issue of whether God is "beyond being" or "being itself" and how unity and being relate to God.

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1. :
- Pico begins by distinguishing between concrete and abstract terms. Concrete terms (e.g., "hot," "bright") refer to qualities possessed by a subject through participation in something external. Abstract terms (e.g., "heat," "light") refer to those

qualities in themselves.

- Applying this distinction to "being," Pico explains that "being" (*ens*) is concrete, meaning it describes entities that participate in "existence" (*esse*). God, however, does not participate in being but (*esse ipsum*). This parallels Thomas Aquinas' teaching.

2. :

- Pico then argues that because God does not participate in anything external, God transcends the concept of "being" as it applies to creatures. Just as "whiteness" is not white in the participatory sense but the very essence of whiteness, God is not "being" in the participatory sense but "above being."

- : This is a direct borrowing from Dionysius the Areopagite, who describes God as "beyond being" (*hyperousios*). For Pico, this does not contradict God as being itself but situates God as the transcendent source of all being.

3. :

- While transcending being, God is also the "plenitude of being." God's essence encompasses all that exists, not as a composite but as a perfect unity. This duality reflects the Neoplatonic idea

that the One is the source of all multiplicity while remaining beyond it.

4. :

- Pico asserts that if we speak of God as "the One," it is less to describe God's nature than to explain how God relates to creation. Unity is the principle by which all things are drawn together and participate in God's essence. However, God's unity is not limited like the unity of creatures but is infinite and absolute.

God is above being because God does not participate in any external essence. However, God is also the source of all being, embodying unity and being in their most perfect, infinite, and undivided forms.

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1. :

- In Chapter V, Pico addresses how human beings can speak of God. He argues that the terms "unity," "truth," "goodness," and "being" are

applied to God analogically. These terms signify God’s perfections but fail to capture God’s infinite nature fully.

- : Echoing Dionysius, Pico emphasizes that God transcends even these highest concepts. Human language falls short, and God’s essence ultimately dwells in the "darkness" of divine simplicity—a state beyond all affirmation or negation.

2. :

- Pico outlines four steps in the ascent to understanding God:

1. : Rejecting all imperfections, God is the infinite source of being, unity, truth, and goodness.
2. : Even the most perfect forms of life, wisdom, or goodness are insufficient to describe God. God transcends even these ascriptions.
3. : God is not only unified but absolute unity itself, containing all perfections in a single, undivided act of being.
4. : At the highest level, God is incomprehensible, surpassing all conceptual and linguistic boundaries. This is the culmination of Dionysian apophatic theology.

3. :

- Pico wrestles with the tension between attributing perfections to God (affirmative theology) and denying all attributes of God (negative theology). He resolves this by asserting that affirmations reveal God's immanence in creation, while negations safeguard God's transcendence.

4. :

- Pico affirms that God is the cause of unity and being in creation. All creatures participate in unity and being to varying degrees, reflecting their dependence on God. However, God is not limited by these categories but is their infinite source.

The journey to understand God involves both affirming God's perfections (unity, truth, goodness, and being) and transcending these affirmations to recognize God's ineffability. God embodies all attributes in a unified, infinite act of being, yet transcends all human understanding of these terms.

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1. :
- God is simultaneously "being itself" (*esse ipsum*) in the Thomistic sense and "beyond being" (*hyperousios*) in the Dionysian sense. This duality reflects Pico's synthesis of Aquinas' metaphysical precision and Dionysius' mystical transcendence.

2. :
- Unity is central to understanding God. For Pico, God is not merely "one" but absolute unity itself, the source of all multiplicity. This unity is inseparable from being, truth, and goodness in God's essence.

3. :
- Chapters IV and V emphasize a mystical ascent to knowledge of God, where the human intellect moves from understanding God as the fullness of being and unity to encountering God as an ineffable mystery. This aligns Pico closely with Neoplatonic and Dionysian traditions.

Chapters IV and V demonstrate Pico's sophisticated theological synthesis:

- : Pico agrees with Aquinas that God is *ipsum esse subsistens*, the plenitude of being and unity.

- : Pico goes beyond Aquinas by emphasizing God's ineffability and transcendence, aligning with Dionysian apophatic theology.

- : Pico integrates Neoplatonism's mystical and hierarchical understanding of unity and being, showing how all creation participates in God while God remains utterly transcendent.

These chapters reveal Pico's innovative blending of Thomistic metaphysics and Neoplatonic mysticism, offering a rich and dynamic vision of God's nature and humanity's ascent toward divine understanding.

USER

Give me transcriptions of Pico's exact words at the key moments of this close reading.

ASSISTANT

Here are transcriptions of Pico's exact words at key moments in *De Ente et Uno*, Chapters IV and V, as they pertain to the issue of God, being, and unity. These passages provide crucial support for the close reading above.

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1. :
- *"The word 'being' (ens) has the aspect of a concrete word. For to say 'being' (ens) and to say 'that which is' (id quod est) is to say the same thing. The abstract of this would seem to be the word esse, in that one calls ens that which participates in esse, in the same way that one calls luminous that which participates in light."*

2. :
- *"We have, therefore, the right to say that God is not being but is above being, and that there is something to being, namely God Himself. If we*

give to God the name of the One, it follows that we avow the one to be above being."

3. :

- *"However, in calling God the One, we do so less to indicate what He is than to show in what manner He is all that is, and how other beings are through Him."*

4. :

- *"God is, then, Being itself, the One Himself, the Good, and the True."*

---

1. :

- *"These terms: being (ens), true, one, good, signify something concrete and as it were participated; wherefore we say again of God that He is being (esse) itself, truth itself, goodness itself, unity itself."*

- *"Thus far indeed we are in the light, but God has placed His dwelling in the shadows. We have then not yet come to God Himself. So long, in short, as that which we say of God is fully understood and entirely comprehended, we are in the light. But all that we say and perceive thus is a mere trifle,*

considering the infinite distance which separates Divinity from the capacity of our minds."

2. :

- *"Blinded by the cloud of the Divine splendor, we cry out with the Prophet: 'I have fainted in Thy halls, O Lord,' finally declaring this one thing about God, that He is incomprehensibly and ineffably above all that we can speak or think of most perfect, placing Him pre-eminently above that unity and that goodness and that truth which we had conceived, and above being (esse) itself."*

3. :

- *"We know Him as superior not only to these four transcendentals, but also to every idea which we could form, to every essence which we could conceive Him to be. Then only, with this total ignorance, does true knowledge commence."*

4. :

- *"Since, finally, these three attributes: unity, truth, and goodness, are united to being by a bond which is eternal, it follows that, if we do not possess them, we no longer exist, even though we may seem to do so; and although others may believe we exist, we are in fact in a state of continuous death rather than of life."*

- : In his assertion that "God is not being but is above being," Pico directly channels Dionysius the Areopagite's apophatic theology while maintaining Thomistic metaphysics by simultaneously calling God "Being itself."

- : The line "God has placed His dwelling in the shadows" invokes the mystical tradition of Dionysius' *Mystical Theology*, emphasizing God's incomprehensibility and surpassing all categories.

- : By calling God "the One Himself," Pico synthesizes Neoplatonic unity with Thomistic metaphysics, framing God as the source of all multiplicity while remaining utterly transcendent.

These exact words illuminate Pico's theological

synthesis, balancing Thomistic metaphysics with the mystical, apophatic tradition of Neoplatonism.

USER

what about ch10 where he appears to identify god with being

ASSISTANT

In Chapter X of *De Ente et Uno*, Pico provides a significant discussion where he seems to identify God with being, even as he previously emphasized God's transcendence above being. This apparent tension reveals Pico's attempt to synthesize Thomistic metaphysics, which understands God as *ipsum esse subsistens* (Being Itself), with Neoplatonic and Dionysian apophatic theology, which places God beyond all categories, including being.

Here are the key passages from Chapter X where Pico identifies God with being, along with a close reading of their implications:

- : *"We conceive God, then, first of all as the perfect totality of act, the plenitude of being itself."*

- :

- Here, Pico affirms a Thomistic view: God is the fullness of being (*plenitudo essendi*), the ultimate source from which all other beings derive their existence. This aligns with Aquinas' idea of God as *ipsum esse subsistens*—the act of existence itself.
- This contrasts with the earlier emphasis on God being "above being," but it can be reconciled if we understand "being itself" in an analogical and transcendent sense, not as a finite or limited category.

- : *"It follows from this concept that He is one, that a term opposite to Him cannot be imagined."*

- :

- In this statement, Pico emphasizes God’s unity as inseparable from His being. For Pico, God is not merely "one" in the numerical sense but is absolute unity, the source of all multiplicity. This reflects both Thomistic divine simplicity and Neoplatonic ideas of unity.
- The phrase "a term opposite to Him cannot be imagined" underscores the transcendence of God’s being and unity. God is beyond opposition or limitation, embodying the absolute fullness of existence.

- : *"God is therefore the fullest plenitude of being, undivided unity, the most solid truth, the most perfect good."*

- :

- Pico integrates being, unity, truth, and goodness as attributes of God, in line with the

medieval tradition that these transcendental qualities are coextensive and rooted in God's essence.
- While earlier chapters stressed the apophatic aspect (God transcending these categories), here Pico affirms God as the archetype and source of these perfections, consistent with Thomistic theology.

- : *"This, if I am not mistaken, is that tetractys or quaternity, by which Pythagoras swore and which he called the principle of ever-flowing nature."*

- :

- Pico identifies the attributes of being, unity, truth, and goodness with the Pythagorean tetractys, showing his synthesis of classical philosophy and Christian theology.
- By framing these attributes as foundational to all existence, Pico reinforces God's role as the cause and source of all reality. This identification

suggests that God’s being is the organizing principle of creation.

- : *"If, as has been described in Chapter VIII above, the good pertains to the final cause, the true to the exemplary, being to the efficient, God as cause will have first of all the attribute of good, then of true, and finally of being."*

- :

- In this causal framework, God’s attributes are related to the causes (final, exemplary, efficient). God is not merely *esse* (being) but also *bonum* (good) and *verum* (truth) as the source of all creation.
- This passage reflects a hierarchical understanding, where goodness (the final cause) is most closely associated with God’s role as creator, but being (as the efficient cause) remains fundamental to understanding God’s essence.

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1. :
- In earlier chapters, Pico emphasizes God's transcendence: God is "above being." In Chapter X, he affirms God as the plenitude of being. These positions are not contradictory but complementary:
- God is beyond finite or participated being (apophatic theology, Chapter V).
- God is the source of all being and *esse ipsum* (affirmative theology, Chapter X).

2. :
- Pico's synthesis of Neoplatonism and Thomism highlights that God's attributes (unity, truth, goodness, being) are unified in His essence. While these terms help describe God's nature, they do so analogically, pointing to His infinite simplicity.

3. :
- Chapter X represents a culmination of Pico's effort to integrate mystical ascent (apophatic) with metaphysical grounding (affirmative). By affirming God as the plenitude of being, Pico ties his speculative theology back to a Thomistic framework.

In Chapter X, Pico explicitly identifies God with being but does so in a way that maintains the transcendence emphasized earlier. By affirming God as *plenitudo essendi*, the fullness of being, Pico aligns with Aquinas' *ipsum esse subsistens*. However, his earlier apophatic language (drawing on Dionysius and Neoplatonism) remains relevant: God transcends finite understandings of being, unity, truth, and goodness, even as He embodies them perfectly. This dual perspective is central to Pico's theological synthesis.